

OnlyFunerals.ai — Complete Operating Plan

SECTION 1: BUSINESS CONCEPT

OnlyFunerals.ai is a trust-first digital platform that helps families navigate funeral planning with clarity, transparent pricing, and guided support — serving both people who are actively planning a funeral under grief and those who want to plan ahead without pressure. The platform connects families to vetted funeral providers, surfaces real pricing where most of the industry hides it, and gives people a structured way to make one of the hardest logistical decisions of their lives without feeling exploited or alone.

Core Problem Solved

The funeral industry is one of the least transparent consumer markets in America. Prices are rarely published. Salespeople are trained to upsell grieving families. The average American funeral costs between \$9,000 and \$15,000, and most families make those decisions within 24 to 48 hours of a death, with no prior research, no comparison shopping, and no advocate in the room. OnlyFunerals.ai fixes the information asymmetry.

Who It Is For

Adult children making decisions for a deceased parent. Spouses in immediate shock. Financially cautious families who suspect they are being overcharged but do not know what fair looks like. Pre-planners who want to remove that burden from their children. And eventually, funeral homes themselves who want qualified leads and a modern front door.

Why Now

The largest generation in American history is aging. Baby Boomers are dying at a rate of approximately 10,000 per day in the US. Gen X adult children are becoming the decision-makers. They research everything online. They expect pricing transparency. They grew up with Yelp, Zillow, and NerdWallet. They expect this tool to exist and are confused that it does not, at least not well.

Why This Could Win

The incumbents in this space are either funeral home directories with no pricing, death-positive lifestyle brands with no utility, or insurance-forward pre-need platforms that feel like a bait-and-switch. A clean, honest, operationally sound platform that puts the family first and earns revenue from providers who benefit from qualified leads can own the trust position in this category quickly. Trust compounds. The category is massive and under-digitized. The brand name, handled correctly, is memorable enough to create earned attention.

Biggest Objections Customers May Have

That the name feels irreverent or inappropriate. That they worry about their personal data being sold to funeral homes who will call them relentlessly. That they do not trust AI to help them with something this serious. That they wonder whether the provider recommendations are paid placements rather than honest matches. All of these are solvable with design, copy, and policy decisions addressed in later sections.

SECTION 2: POSITIONING

Brand Positioning Statement

OnlyFunerals.ai is the only platform built entirely around the family, not the funeral home. We give grieving and planning families the pricing clarity, logistical guidance, and trusted provider connections they need to make confident decisions during one of the most vulnerable moments of their lives.

One Sentence Elevator Pitch

We are NerdWallet for funeral planning — transparent pricing, trusted providers, and a guided process for families who deserve better than the industry has given them.

Three Tagline Options

1. “Plan with clarity. Grieve without regret.”
2. “Because they deserved better than guesswork.”
3. “Honest answers for the hardest days.”

How to Make the Brand Feel Trustworthy Instead of Gimmicky

The name OnlyFunerals.ai will trigger one of two reactions: people will either find it bold and direct or mildly inappropriate. The antidote is execution. The brand must look and feel like a quiet, competent law firm meets a modern financial planning tool. No dark humor. No death-positive counterculture. No startuppy language. Clean white space, warm neutrals, authoritative typography, and copy that is written for someone who is scared and exhausted, not entertained. The AI element should be positioned as a tool that does the research so the family does not have to, not as a chatbot pretending to understand grief.

Key Tone Words

Steady. Clear. Trustworthy. Unhurried. Practical. Warm. Direct. Dignified.

Words to Avoid

Journey. Solutions. Seamless. Loved one (overused to the point of being hollow). Innovative. Disruptive. AI-powered (lead with the outcome, not the technology). Affordable (sounds discount). Cheap. Personalized (meaningless). Celebrate. Platform.

SECTION 3: CUSTOMER SEGMENTS

Segment 1: Adult Child Planning for a Parent

Pains: Making decisions fast with no prior knowledge, fear of being upsold, guilt about price shopping during grief, coordinating with siblings who may disagree, geographic distance from the deceased.

Needs: A clear checklist of what needs to happen in what order. Honest pricing from local providers. Someone to tell them what is legally required versus what is optional. A way to communicate progress to family.

Emotional state: Grief layered with logistics overwhelm, decision fatigue, and guilt about not having planned this earlier.

Buying triggers: A parent has just died or is actively dying in hospice. A sibling or spouse said “someone needs to figure this out.”

Likely objections: “I need to make a decision today, I don’t have time to research.” This is actually an opportunity. Speed and clarity are the offer.

Segment 2: Spouse in Immediate Grief

Pains: Navigating bureaucracy alone while devastated. Not knowing what the deceased would have wanted. Fear of making an irreversible decision wrong.

Needs: Hand-holding. A single point of contact. Someone who will not try to sell them something.

Emotional state: The most acute of any segment. Shock. Disorientation. Vulnerability.

Buying triggers: The death just happened, often unexpectedly. They searched for help at 2am.

Likely objections: They may not trust anything digital in this state. The human escalation path is non-negotiable for this segment.

Segment 3: Pre-Planner Researching in Advance

Pains: Not knowing where to start. Worried about being sold a prepaid plan they cannot trust. Wanting to protect their family from making hard decisions in grief.

Needs: Education about options. A place to document wishes. A way to share that document with family.

Emotional state: Calm, slightly anxious, practical. Often has more time and patience than other segments.

Buying triggers: Just watched a parent die without a plan. Turned 60. Had a health scare. Did estate planning and realized they missed this piece.

Likely objections: “I’ll do this later.” This segment is great for content and email nurture.

Segment 4: Price-Sensitive Family

Pains: Receiving a quote that feels outrageously high with no way to know if it is legitimate. Fear of judgment for asking about cost. Pressure from funeral home salespeople.

Needs: Transparent cost comparison. Knowledge of legal minimums. Cremation alternatives. Government assistance options if applicable.

Emotional state: Stressed, possibly embarrassed, determined not to go into debt for a funeral.

Buying triggers: Received their first quote and are in sticker shock.

Likely objections: They may distrust any platform that makes money from funeral homes.

Disclosure of the business model matters here.

Segment 5: Premium White Glove Customer

Pains: Lack of coordination at the high end. Premium funeral homes are not necessarily better organized. Wants everything handled without asking.

Needs: A concierge who manages every detail, communicates proactively, and handles logistics across venues, vendors, and timing.

Emotional state: Grief plus high expectations. Used to having things managed.

Buying triggers: Wealth. Complexity of the service they want. No time to manage it themselves.

Likely objections: "I can just call the funeral home directly." The value proposition must be coordination, advocacy, and accountability the funeral home alone cannot provide.

SECTION 4: MVP BUSINESS MODEL

Option Comparison

Lead generation: Simplest mechanics. Families submit a quote request. Funeral homes pay per qualified lead. No technology dependency. Proven model (see auto insurance, mortgage).

Margin is thin at scale but workable early. Risk: lead quality disputes with providers.

Funeral home comparison marketplace: More complex. Requires provider data, pricing data, and review systems. Higher trust ceiling if done right. Takes longer to build and requires significant provider supply before it is useful to consumers.

Concierge planning service: High margin, high labor. Serves premium segment well. Hard to scale. Best as a revenue layer on top of lead gen, not the foundation.

Subscription planning tool: Great for pre-planners. Low conversion, low urgency, high churn risk. Wrong as a first revenue model.

SaaS for funeral providers: B2B sales cycle. Wrong for year one. Interesting in year two or three once you have consumer traction and data.

Recommendation: Sequence

First: Lead generation. Get the intake form right. Build the provider network manually. Route leads, collect fees, learn the market.

Second: Comparison marketplace with transparent pricing. Build this once you have enough provider relationships and consumer traffic to make the comparison meaningful.

Third: Concierge service and pre-planning subscription. Layer these on once the brand has trust equity and you understand what customers actually need help with.

SECTION 5: REVENUE PLAN

Lead Fees

Immediate. Funeral homes pay \$200 to \$400 per qualified lead depending on service type, geography, and exclusivity. At-need (immediate death) leads command the highest fees.

Exclusive routing commands a premium over shared leads. This model is understood and accepted by funeral home operators who already buy leads from directory sites.

Assumed margin: 80 to 90 percent. Primary cost is traffic acquisition.

Affiliate or Referral Revenue

Relevant for adjacent services: death certificates (third-party expeditors), estate attorneys, grief counseling, celebrants, florists, catering. Referral fees of \$100 to \$180 per conversion depending on service. Add these once traffic is established.

Premium Concierge Packages

\$500 to \$2,500 flat fee for a human coordinator who manages the full funeral planning process. Target: premium and overwhelmed segments. Margin depends heavily on how the coordinator role is structured. If contractors, margin can reach 50 to 60 percent.

Pre-Need Planning Packages

\$99 to \$299 one-time fee for a structured planning tool that includes a document organizer, wishes template, provider matching, and optional annual review. This is a sleeper revenue stream with high lifetime value potential if it converts to at-need leads later.

Provider Subscriptions

\$350 to \$600 per month for funeral homes to have a verified listing, access to lead routing, and a dashboard. Build this after you have proven consumer traffic. Do not sell subscriptions to providers before you can demonstrate value.

Advertising

Flag: Advertising on a funeral planning platform is a trust risk unless handled carefully. If pursued, it must be limited to clearly relevant categories and never feel intrusive during the active planning flow. Consider it only for pre-planning content pages, not grief-state intake flows.

SECTION 6: COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Main Competitor Categories

Legacy funeral directories: Outdated UX, no pricing, designed around the funeral home's needs not the family's. They win on domain authority and age. They lose on everything else.

Insurance-forward pre-need platforms: Often lead with a free planning tool that converts to a life insurance or prepaid funeral policy sale. Families feel tricked when they realize the planning tool was a funnel.

Death-positive lifestyle brands: Strong aesthetic, weak utility. Good at building community, bad at closing the transaction when it counts.

Price comparison aggregators: A few exist in limited markets. Most lack supply depth or consumer trust. Pricing data is often stale or self-reported.

Direct funeral home websites: Increasingly better designed but inherently self-serving. No comparison possible.

What Most Competitors Do Badly

Pricing transparency. Emotional intelligence in UX. Clear explanation of what is legally required versus optional. Genuine neutrality in provider recommendations. Mobile-first design for people searching at 2am in distress.

How OnlyFunerals.ai Can Be Different

Publish real pricing where providers will allow it. Design every touchpoint as if the user is exhausted and scared. Build the intake flow to reduce decisions, not multiply them. Be radically transparent about how the business makes money. Let families choose whether to be contacted by one provider or three. Give them control. That alone separates this from almost everything else in the category.

Where Trust Can Be Won or Lost

Won: Pricing transparency. Clear disclosure of the business model. Fast human response. Provider vetting language that is specific rather than vague. Testimonials from families, not funeral homes.

Lost: Auto-dialing leads to five funeral homes who all call within 30 seconds. Any language that sounds like upselling. AI responses during moments of acute grief. Privacy policy language that is evasive.

SECTION 7: WEBSITE STRUCTURE

Homepage

Goal: Establish trust and route the visitor to the correct path within 10 seconds.

Primary CTA: "Get honest pricing near you" or "Start your free plan."

Content blocks: Clear statement of what this is. Two to three path selectors (planning now, planning ahead, comparing options). Trust signals. A brief plain-English explanation of how the service works and how the business makes money.

How It Works

Goal: Remove suspicion and explain the model.

Primary CTA: "See providers near you."

Content blocks: Three to four step explanation. Business model disclosure. FAQ preview. What families can expect after submitting a request.

Funeral Planning by City or State

Goal: SEO capture and local trust.

Primary CTA: "Compare providers in [city]."

Content blocks: Local provider listings. Average cost ranges for the area. State-specific legal notes. Flagged assumption: state law variations require legal review before publishing specific requirements.

Compare Providers

Goal: The core marketplace function.

Primary CTA: "Request quotes from selected providers."

Content blocks: Filter by service type, price range, rating, location. Provider profile cards. Verified badge explanation. Review display.

Pricing or Quote Request

Goal: Lead capture.

Primary CTA: "Get your free price estimate."

Content blocks: Intake form (simplified). What happens next. Privacy reassurance.

Expected response time.

Pre-Planning Resources

Goal: Serve the advance planner and capture email.

Primary CTA: "Start your free planning document."

Content blocks: What pre-planning involves. Downloadable checklist. Guide to documenting your wishes. FAQ for pre-planners.

Grief and Logistics Resources

Goal: Serve families beyond the transaction. Build trust. Reduce bounce.

Primary CTA: "Download the at-need checklist."

Content blocks: What to do in the first 24 hours. How to obtain a death certificate. What documents you will need. Emotional support resources. Legal checklist.

FAQ

Goal: Handle objections before they kill conversion.

Primary CTA: "Still have questions? Talk to someone."

Content blocks: How does OnlyFunerals.ai make money. Are providers paying to appear. What if I need help right now. Is my information sold. What does the service cost families.

About

Goal: Humanize the brand and establish credibility.

Primary CTA: "Meet our team" or "Read our standards."

Content blocks: Origin story. Team bios if appropriate. Provider vetting standards. The promise to families.

Contact

Goal: Human access point.

Primary CTA: "Talk to a planning guide."

Content blocks: Phone number if available. Email. Expected response time. Chat if staffed.

Trust and Safety

Goal: Pre-empt the biggest objections.

Primary CTA: "Read our provider standards."

Content blocks: How providers are vetted. Privacy policy plain language summary. What OnlyFunerals.ai will never do with your information. Complaints and resolution process.

Partner With Us

Goal: Funeral home acquisition.

Primary CTA: "Apply to join our network."

Content blocks: Why providers join. What families expect. Lead volume estimates if applicable. Application or inquiry form. Pricing tiers if appropriate.

Dashboard or App Area

Goal: Planning tool for pre-planners and at-need families managing an active case.
Primary CTA: "Continue your plan."

Content blocks: Task checklist. Document upload. Provider communication thread. Saved providers. Sharing link for family members.

SECTION 8: HOMEPAGE WIREFRAME

Section 1: Navigation Bar

Purpose: Orientation and trust.

Content: Logo (left). Nav links: How It Works, Compare Providers, Pre-Planning, Resources, For Funeral Homes. CTA button: "Get Started" (right). Optional: phone number if staffed.

Trust element: Phone number signals human access.

Section 2: Hero

Purpose: Stop the scroll, establish what this is, earn one more second of attention.

Headline: "Funeral planning shouldn't feel like a negotiation."

Subhead: "OnlyFunerals.ai gives families real pricing, vetted providers, and a guided process during one of the hardest decisions they'll ever make. Free to use. No pressure."

CTA: Two options. "I need help now" and "I'm planning ahead."

Trust elements: "Free for families" badge. "We never sell your data without consent" line. Brief explanation of business model in two sentences below the fold.

Content notes: Hero image should be calm, warm, natural light. A hand holding another hand. An empty chair. Something that signals acknowledgment of loss without being morbid. No stock photo of a funeral home or a coffin.

Section 3: Path Selector

Purpose: Route the visitor without making them read.

Three cards: "Someone just died," "Planning for a parent," "Planning for myself."

Each card: Icon, headline, one sentence, arrow CTA.

Trust element: None required here. Clarity is the trust signal.

Section 4: How It Works

Purpose: Remove suspicion in 60 seconds.

Three steps: Tell us what you need. We match you with vetted providers. You choose who to contact. No one calls you without permission.

Subhead: "How we make money: Funeral homes pay us a fee when a family contacts them. That fee never changes what you see or what you pay."

CTA: "See how providers are vetted."

Trust element: Business model disclosure in plain language. This is non-negotiable.

Section 5: Social Proof

Purpose: Borrowed trust while the brand is new.

Content: Two to three family testimonials with first name and state. One or two press mentions if available. If no press, a founding team credibility statement.

Trust elements: Real names and states if possible. Avoid vague testimonials.

Section 6: Cost Transparency Preview

Purpose: Demonstrate the core value proposition before asking for anything.

Headline: "Here is what a funeral actually costs in America."

Content: A simple chart or range display showing national average costs by service type. Direct cremation, traditional burial, graveside service. Linked to the pricing guide.

CTA: "Get pricing for your area."

Trust element: Source citation for the numbers shown.

Section 7: Provider Network

Purpose: Establish supply credibility.

Headline: "Providers who believe families deserve better."

Content: Number of vetted providers. States covered. Vetting criteria listed in three bullet points. Provider logos if permission is granted.

CTA: "See providers near you."

Section 8: Pre-Planning CTA Band

Purpose: Convert the pre-planner who has been reading.

Headline: "Your family should never have to figure this out in 24 hours."

Subhead: "Start a free planning document today. Share it whenever you're ready."

CTA: "Start free."

Trust element: "No payment required. No sales calls." in small text beneath.

Section 9: Resources Preview

Purpose: Show depth without requiring commitment.

Headline: "What to do when someone dies."

Content: Three to four article previews: first 24 hours, obtaining a death certificate, what the funeral home cannot legally require you to buy, how to handle a death out of state.

CTA: "See all resources."

Section 10: Footer

Purpose: Completeness and compliance.

Content: Logo. Nav links. Privacy policy. Terms. Business model disclosure link.

Contact. For funeral homes link. State coverage indicator.

Trust element: "OnlyFunerals.ai is free for families. Funeral homes pay to receive qualified leads. We never sell your contact information to third parties without your explicit permission."

SECTION 9: UX FLOW

What They See First

A calm, quiet homepage. Headline that acknowledges why they are here without being dramatic. Two clear action buttons. No pop-up. No chat widget opening unprompted. No auto-play video.

What Choices They Get

Immediately: “I need help now” or “I’m planning ahead.” That is the only choice they need to make to move forward. Everything branches from there.

How to Reduce Overwhelm

Progressive disclosure. Show one question at a time in the intake flow. Never show a long form. Lead with the easiest question, not the most sensitive one. Save progress automatically if they navigate away.

How the Quote or Intake Flow Should Work

Step 1: What type of service are you looking for? (cremation, traditional burial, graveside, not sure)

Step 2: What city or zip code?

Step 3: What is the timing? (death has already occurred, within the next few days, planning ahead)

Step 4 (conditional on at-need): What is your timeline for making a decision?

Step 5: What matters most to you? (price, proximity, specific religious or cultural requirements, other)

Step 6: How would you like providers to reach you? (email only, phone during business hours, I want to reach out to them myself)

Step 7: First name and contact information.

Never ask for the deceased’s name, age, or cause of death in the public intake flow. That information can be collected later by the provider or concierge. Asking for it upfront feels invasive and creates unnecessary friction.

Where Trust Signals Belong

Privacy language appears immediately after the contact information field: “We share your information only with providers you approve. We do not sell your data.” Business model disclosure appears on the How It Works page and in the hero section.

Testimonials appear mid-scroll on the homepage, not at the bottom where no one reads them. A human contact option (call or email) should be visible throughout the intake flow, not just at the end. The confirmation screen should tell the family exactly what happens next, when to expect contact, and how to stop the process if they change their mind.

SECTION 10: FEATURES

MVP: Must Have

Intake form with progressive disclosure. City or zip-based provider matching (even if manual on the backend initially). Quote request routing to matched providers. Provider profiles with service types, price ranges (where available), and contact information. At-need checklist downloadable as PDF. Pre-planning document template downloadable as PDF. Email confirmation to family with next steps. Email notification to provider with lead details. Human contact option (email at minimum, phone if staffed). Privacy policy and business model disclosure pages.

Mobile-optimized design throughout.

MVP: Nice to Have But Should Wait

Review and rating system (requires volume before it is meaningful). Real-time chat (requires staffing or AI, both carry risk if not done right). Provider comparison table with live pricing (requires signed provider agreements to publish pricing). Document organizer with upload (adds complexity and security requirements). Obituary builder (useful but not urgent).

Phase 2

Authenticated user accounts with saved plans and documents. Provider dashboard with lead management. Review and rating system. Comparison table with provider-submitted pricing. Referral network for adjacent services. Email nurture sequences for pre-planners.

Phase 3

AI assistant for answering logistics questions (flagged: must be paired with clear disclaimer and human escalation, never positioned as grief support). SaaS dashboard for funeral home operators. Pre-need document vault with family sharing.

Mobile app for ongoing case management.

What Should Not Be Built Yet

An AI grief counselor or chatbot. A live video consultation product. A funeral home management system. A payment processing layer between family and funeral home. Any feature that requires you to hold family money or act as an escrow agent.

SECTION 11: SEO AND CONTENT STRATEGY

Top Content Pillars

Pricing transparency (what funerals cost, how to compare, what is required by law).

At-need logistics (what to do when someone dies, step by step). Pre-planning (how to plan your own funeral, how to document your wishes). Consumer rights (what funeral homes cannot legally charge you for, the FTC Funeral Rule). Grief and next steps (practical guides for the weeks after a death).

Best Initial SEO Pages

“Average cost of a funeral in [state]” pages for all 50 states. “What to do when someone dies in [state].” “Cheapest funeral options in [city].” “Direct cremation vs traditional burial: cost and process.” “What the FTC Funeral Rule means for your family.” “How to get a death certificate in [state].” “Can a funeral home require embalming?”

Local SEO Opportunities

City-level landing pages for the top 100 metro areas. “Funeral homes in [city] with pricing.” “Cremation services in [city].” “At-need funeral help in [city].” Google Business Profile for any physical presence or service area.

Long Tail Search Intent Ideas

“My mom just died what do I do first.” “How much does a funeral cost without embalming.” “Can I have a funeral without a funeral home.” “What happens if I can’t afford a funeral.” “How to plan my own funeral so my kids don’t have to.” “Is pre-paying for a funeral a good idea.” “What documents do I need when someone dies.”

Trust Content Topics

How OnlyFunerals.ai vets providers. What the FTC Funeral Rule protects you from. Questions you should always ask a funeral home before signing anything. How funeral home pricing actually works. Red flags to watch for when arranging a funeral.

Conversion Content Topics

“Get a free funeral price estimate in your area.” “Start your pre-planning document today.” “Compare cremation providers near you.”

20 Article Starter Content Plan

1. What to do in the first 24 hours after a death
2. Average funeral costs by state in 2025
3. Direct cremation vs traditional burial: a plain comparison
4. The FTC Funeral Rule: what it is and how it protects you

5. What a funeral home is legally required to give you before you sign anything
6. How to compare funeral homes without feeling like you're shopping
7. What you do not have to buy: optional funeral services explained
8. How to get a death certificate and how many copies you will need
9. What happens to a body between death and burial
10. How to plan your own funeral so your family does not have to guess
11. Green burial and natural alternatives: what they are and where they are legal
(flagged: legality varies by state, requires review)
12. What pre-paying for a funeral actually means and the risks involved
13. How to handle a death that happens out of state
14. Military funeral benefits: what families are entitled to
15. What to do if you cannot afford a funeral
16. Cremation myths families believe that are not true
17. How to write an obituary that actually sounds like the person
18. What to expect at a funeral home arrangement conference
19. How to choose a funeral home you can trust
20. Pre-planning checklist: everything your family will need to know

SECTION 12: TRUST AND BRAND RISK

The Name

OnlyFunerals.ai will draw comparisons to OnlyFans. This is not a rumor risk, it is a certainty. Some people will think it is a parody. This risk is real and should be addressed head-on rather than ignored. The offset is relentless execution. A brand that looks and behaves like a serious professional service within three seconds of landing on the page can survive a provocative name. The name also has upside: it is memorable, it is searchable, it signals focus and specificity, and it will generate press simply by existing.

Mitigation: The visual identity must be impeccably serious. The copy must be warm and authoritative, never clever in a way that reads as flippant. The About page should address the name directly with confidence, not defensiveness.

AI in the Name

Some families in acute grief will distrust anything with AI in the name. They want a human. The offset is to lead every communication with human availability and position the AI functionality as behind-the-scenes research, not front-line interaction with grieving people.

Data Privacy

The intake form collects information from people in their most vulnerable state. Any perception that this data is being sold or that funeral homes are auto-dialing leads will destroy the brand fast. This is an existential risk. The business model must be disclosed clearly. Lead routing must be permissioned. Families should have the option to contact providers themselves rather than the other way around.

Provider Quality

If a vetted provider behaves badly toward a family referred by this platform, that family will associate the experience with the brand. Vetting standards must be enforced, not just published. A clear complaint and resolution process must exist before launch.

Regulatory Risk

Funeral industry regulation is state-specific and complex. The FTC Funeral Rule provides a federal floor but states layer additional requirements on top. Any state-specific legal guidance on the platform must be reviewed by an attorney familiar with funeral industry law in each relevant state. Flagged clearly: do not publish specific legal requirements for any state without a qualified legal review.

Grief Exploitation Perception

Any hint that the platform is taking advantage of people in grief will be weaponized on social media. The business model must be structurally designed so that the family's experience never degrades because of revenue pressure. Lead volume targets should never come at the expense of the quality control process.

SECTION 13: OPERATIONS

Intake Handling

In MVP phase, intake forms route to a shared inbox or CRM. A human reviews each submission, confirms match criteria, and routes the lead to the appropriate provider within a defined SLA. Target: within one hour for at-need submissions, within four hours for all others. Automated email confirmation to the family goes immediately. Manual provider notification follows until the routing logic is built.

Partner Onboarding

Funeral homes apply via a Partner With Us form. Basic vetting: verify state licensure, check BBB standing, review any public complaints (NFDA, state licensing boards, Google reviews). Phone or video call with a team member before activation. Signed provider agreement covering lead fees, data use, and conduct standards. Provider receives a dashboard login (phase two) or email-based lead delivery (MVP).

Customer Support

A monitored email address and ideally a phone line (even if answered asynchronously) from day one. Families in acute grief cannot wait 48 hours for a reply. Target response time: under two hours during business hours. After-hours: automated acknowledgment with a clear response time commitment. A human must be reachable for urgent at-need situations.

Quote Routing

MVP: manual routing via CRM or even a structured spreadsheet while volume is low. Match by zip code radius, service type requested, and provider capacity. Log every lead, every routing decision, and every provider response. This data is gold for building the matching algorithm later.

CRM

HubSpot free tier or Airtable is sufficient for MVP. Must capture: lead source, date, service type, geography, provider matched, provider response time, family outcome if known, lead fee invoiced and paid. Build this structure from day one. Do not let it become a mess.

Privacy and Data Handling

Collect only what is necessary for matching. Store it securely. Do not share contact information with providers until family consent is confirmed. Publish a plain-language privacy policy, not a legal wall of text. Have an attorney review both the formal policy and the plain-language version. Flagged: if health information is ever collected (hospice status, cause of death), HIPAA implications should be reviewed. Avoid collecting health information at intake.

Escalation Process

Family complaints about a provider: immediate acknowledgment, investigation within 24 hours, provider suspension if warranted pending review. Provider disputes about lead quality: defined criteria for what constitutes a qualified lead documented in the provider agreement. Fraud concerns: direct escalation to a named human, not a form.

What Can Be Automated

Lead intake confirmation emails. Provider lead notification emails. Billing and invoicing for lead fees (Stripe). Basic analytics reporting. Content publishing schedule.

What Must Stay Human

Intake review for nuance and completeness. Provider quality decisions. Any family interaction involving distress or complaint. Regulatory or legal questions. Any situation that falls outside defined parameters.

SECTION 14: TECH STACK

What to Build in Lovable First

The homepage and marketing pages. The intake form with progressive disclosure. The pre-planning document template flow. The provider-facing Partner With Us application form. The How It Works and trust pages. Lovable handles this well for a founder-led build and produces something presentable to investors without requiring a full engineering team.

Where Supabase Fits

User authentication when accounts are added. Lead intake data storage. Provider profile data. Form submissions. Any structured data that needs to be retrieved, filtered, or reported on. Supabase is a strong choice because it handles PostgreSQL, auth, and real-time well, and integrates naturally with Lovable builds.

When Custom Code Becomes Necessary

When provider matching logic needs to be anything more than geographic radius matching. When the lead routing engine needs conditional logic beyond what no-code tools handle cleanly. When provider dashboards need real-time lead status updates. When the CMS cannot handle the volume and structure of the SEO content plan. Plan for this at around the six to nine month mark if traction is real.

No-Code vs Coded

No-code (Lovable, Webflow, or similar): All marketing pages. Intake form flows. Document templates. Email sequences (Mailchimp or ConvertKit). Invoice and billing (Stripe directly). Coded or low-code with engineering: Provider matching algorithm. Authenticated dashboards. Lead routing engine. Any data pipeline or analytics beyond basic.

What Should Not Be Overbuilt

The AI assistant. Do not build a custom AI chat product. Use an API call to an existing model if needed. The review system. Build it when you have enough volume to make it meaningful, not before. The provider dashboard. Start with email. Build the dashboard when providers are asking for it. A mobile app. The mobile web experience is sufficient for years one and two.

SECTION 15: FINANCIAL MODEL

All figures are estimates. Label these as assumptions for any investor conversation.

Startup Costs (One-Time)

Domain, hosting, tooling: \$500 to \$1,500. Lovable and Supabase setup: \$200 to \$500. Legal (business formation, provider agreement template, privacy policy review): \$3,000 to \$8,000. Brand and design: \$5,000 to \$15,000 depending on whether you use a freelancer or small agency. First content batch (20 articles): \$3,000 to \$8,000 if outsourced. Total estimated startup cost: \$12,000 to \$33,000. Can be compressed to \$8,000 to \$15,000 if the founder handles copy and design direction personally.

Monthly Operating Costs

Hosting and tooling: \$200 to \$500. CRM and email: \$100 to \$300. SEO tools: \$100 to \$200. Content (ongoing): \$1,500 to \$4,000. Customer support (contractor initially): \$1,500 to \$3,000. Paid acquisition testing: \$1,000 to \$3,000. Total: \$4,400 to \$11,000 per month.

Conversion Assumptions

Assumption A: 1,000 monthly visitors in month three (SEO plus modest paid). Assumption B: 5 percent of visitors submit an intake form. Assumption C: 80 percent of submissions become qualified leads routed to providers. Assumption D: average lead fee of \$150.

Month three implied revenue: $1,000 \times 0.05 \times 0.80 \times \$150 = \$6,000$.

Revenue Scenarios at Month 12

Conservative: 3,000 monthly visitors, 4 percent intake rate, \$120 average lead fee. Monthly revenue: approximately \$14,400.

Base case: 8,000 monthly visitors, 5 percent intake rate, \$150 average lead fee. Monthly revenue: approximately \$48,000.

Best case: 20,000 monthly visitors, 5 percent intake rate, \$160 average lead fee plus 10 percent of leads upgrading to concierge at \$750 average. Monthly revenue: approximately \$144,000.

Flagged assumptions: Visitor volume depends heavily on SEO traction timeline and paid acquisition efficiency. Lead fee rates are based on comparable industries and may vary significantly by geography and provider willingness. Concierge attachment rate is speculative until tested.

Path to Profitability

Base case scenario reaches operating breakeven at approximately month eight to ten assuming costs remain controlled and no full-time hires are made before month six.

SECTION 16: 90 DAY LAUNCH PLAN

Weeks 1 to 2: Research and Positioning

Interview 10 to 15 people who have planned a funeral in the last three years. Identify the top five moments of friction, confusion, and distrust. Confirm the positioning resonates or adjust it.

Research the top 20 target metro areas for initial geographic focus. Identify 20 funeral home

operators who might be early partners. Review FTC Funeral Rule and flag state-specific compliance questions for legal review.

Weeks 3 to 4: Brand and Copy Foundation

Finalize name usage, logo mark, color palette, and typography. Write the core pages: homepage, how it works, trust and safety, about, FAQ, partner with us. Write the intake form copy and confirmation email sequence. Build the plain-language privacy policy draft (then attorney review). Write the provider agreement first draft (then attorney review).

Weeks 5 to 6: MVP Build

Build in Lovable: homepage, intake form, how it works, trust page, partner application form. Connect Supabase for form data capture. Set up Stripe for eventual lead fee invoicing. Connect domain. Set up CRM (HubSpot or Airtable). Set up email system (Mailchimp or ConvertKit).

Weeks 7 to 8: Content and SEO Foundation

Publish first 10 articles from the content plan. Set up Google Analytics and Search Console. Submit sitemap. Build first five city-level SEO landing pages. Optimize all pages for core target keywords.

Weeks 9 to 10: Partner Recruitment

Personally contact 20 target funeral homes via phone and email. Goal: five to ten signed provider agreements before launch. For each: collect service types, geography, price ranges if willing, photos, and a brief profile. Brief them on how leads will be delivered and what the expectations are.

Weeks 11 to 12: Soft Launch and Testing

Invite 20 to 30 people from target segments to test the intake flow and give feedback. Fix friction points. Run \$500 to \$1,000 in Google Ads against high-intent keywords to test intake conversion before investing further. Route first test leads to providers and document the end-to-end experience. Identify every place the process breaks or delays. Fix them.

Week 13: Launch

Announce via owned channels. Pitch two to three local journalists in target metro areas with the pricing transparency angle. Submit to relevant newsletters and communities. Begin ongoing content publishing cadence.

Post-Launch Optimization

Weekly: Review conversion rate, lead quality complaints, provider response times. Monthly: Content expansion, new city pages, SEO ranking review. Quarterly: Provider network expansion, pricing model review, feature prioritization based on what families are actually asking for.

SECTION 17: INVESTOR OR PARTNER SUMMARY

OnlyFunerals.ai: One Page

The funeral industry generates approximately \$21 billion annually in the United States. Approximately 3.3 million Americans die each year. Every one of those deaths requires a family to make significant logistical and financial decisions, typically within 24 to 48 hours, under extreme emotional distress, with almost no pricing transparency and no independent advocate. The FTC has regulated funeral home pricing disclosure since 1984 through the Funeral Rule, yet most families still cannot compare prices before committing to a provider. The internet has

not solved this problem in any meaningful way. Existing directories are outdated. Comparison tools are either nonexistent or built around insurance sales rather than consumer advocacy. OnlyFunerals.ai enters this gap as a trust-first platform that gives families real pricing information, vetted provider matching, and guided logistics support, free to families, funded by lead fees paid by participating funeral homes.

The business model is proven in adjacent categories: Zillow, NerdWallet, and AutoTrader all monetize the information asymmetry between consumers and service providers without compromising the consumer relationship. In each case, the platform that earned consumer trust first won the category.

The market opportunity is large, recurring, and structurally resistant to disruption from funeral homes themselves because no individual provider can be neutral. The regulatory environment actually supports the value proposition. The FTC Funeral Rule mandates pricing disclosure; OnlyFunerals.ai makes compliance into a feature.

Year one revenue target in the base case: \$400,000 to \$600,000 gross, primarily from lead fees.

Year two with comparison marketplace and concierge layer: \$1.2M to \$2.5M depending on geographic expansion. The business is capital-light, has high operating margins once the platform is built, and the category has no dominant digital incumbent.

The risk is execution: trust is slow to earn and fast to lose in this category. The team must be operationally disciplined, the provider network must be genuinely vetted, and the family experience must hold under the emotional pressure of real at-need situations.

SECTION 18: FINAL VERDICT

Is this business smart or stupid?

Smart. Notably smart. The market is large, the problem is real, the incumbents are mediocre, and the regulatory environment actively supports the value proposition. The name carries risk but also carries upside in earned attention. This is a real business disguised as a provocative brand.

What version of it is most viable?

A lean lead generation platform with a strong content and SEO foundation, a manually operated backend, five to fifteen vetted provider relationships per metro area, and an obsessive focus on the family's experience at intake. Not a marketplace yet. Not an AI product yet. A smart, well-designed consumer advocate that makes money by connecting families to providers who are willing to pay for qualified, high-intent leads.

What you should absolutely avoid

Building the AI assistant before you have the human process working. Auto-routing leads to multiple providers simultaneously without family consent. Publishing state-specific legal guidance without an attorney review. Building provider-facing SaaS before you have consumer traction. Adding insurance or pre-need financial products in year one. Letting the brand drift toward humor or irreverence. Collecting any health information at intake without legal review. Optimizing for lead volume before you have quality control figured out.

Fastest path to revenue

Sign five to ten funeral homes manually. Route your first leads by email. Charge a flat fee per qualified lead. Do this before the website is perfect. The intake form, the provider agreement, and the routing email are the entire business in month one. Everything else is infrastructure.

What would make this a real company instead of just another pretty website
Pricing transparency that no competitor will match. Provider vetting standards that are actually enforced. A family experience that holds up in a real at-need situation at 2am. An operator who treats the emotional weight of this category with the seriousness it deserves. Press coverage based on consumer advocacy, not a launch announcement. And eventually, enough consumer trust that funeral homes come to you because families ask for you by name.

ADDENDUM

Brand Moodboard Direction

Quiet authority. Think Vanguard meets a high-end estate attorney. Clean white space. Warm neutrals. Photography that acknowledges loss without dwelling in darkness. Natural light through a window. Hands. A handwritten note. An old photograph on a table. Nothing stock. Nothing that looks like a funeral home website.

Color and Typography Direction

Primary: A deep warm navy or slate, not black, not cold blue. Something that reads as stable and trustworthy.

Secondary: Warm cream or off-white for backgrounds.

Accent: A restrained warm gold or aged brass for CTAs and highlights.

Avoid: Pastels. Anything that reads as clinical or sterile. Anything that reads as celebratory.

Typography: A serif display font with personality for headlines (something with the weight of authority but not the stiffness of a law firm). A clean humanist sans-serif for body copy and interface elements. The same logic as The Statesman pairing but shifted toward warmth and approachability.

Homepage Hero Copy Option

“Funeral planning shouldn’t feel like a negotiation.

OnlyFunerals.ai gives families real pricing, vetted providers, and a guided process during one of the hardest decisions they’ll ever make. Free to use. No pressure. No hidden agendas.”

Three CTA Options

1. “Get honest pricing near you”
2. “I need help right now”
3. “Start your free plan”

Lovable Build Prompt

Build a clean, trust-first multi-page website for a company called OnlyFunerals.ai. The brand helps families plan funerals with transparent pricing and guided support. The site should feel like a quiet, authoritative financial planning tool: warm neutrals, deep navy, clean serif headlines, humanist sans-serif body copy, generous white space. No dark or morbid imagery.

Pages to build: Homepage with hero, path selector (three cards: someone just died, planning for a parent, planning for myself), how it works section, social proof section, pre-planning CTA band, and footer with business model disclosure. Include a separate intake form page with progressive disclosure, one question per screen. Include a Partner With Us application page. Include a How It Works page. Include a Trust and Safety page.

The intake form should collect: service type, zip code, timing, priorities, contact preference, and name and email. Confirm with a warm plain-language thank you screen. Connect form

submissions to a Supabase table. No user authentication needed at this stage. Mobile-first design throughout.